



Patel’s peers dial up alarm on fitness

Critics fear FBI pick may use agency to exact the retribution he has vowed

BY PERRY STEIN, MARK BERMAN AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

If Kash Patel has his way, he has written, the FBI’s top ranks will be fired. The bureau’s headquarters in downtown Washington will be emptied out and shuttered, and its authority will be “dramatically limited and refocused,” he wrote in his 2023 book.

President-elect Donald Trump’s choice of Patel to lead the FBI has set off spasms of alarm among many national security veterans, law enforcement officials and others who have worked with him. The former prosecutor and national security aide appears to have secured the support of at least some key Republican senators, but critics say Patel lacks the record and temperament needed to run the country’s premier law enforcement agency. They point to his lack of experience as well as his history of remarks attacking Trump opponents and threatening to punish perceived foes.

“The idea that he is going to become the FBI director is appalling,” said Charles Kupperman, who was deputy national security adviser in the previous Trump

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Cabinet: Trump’s selections for top jobs are gliding toward approval. **A7**

A flurry of executive actions as Biden exits

Outgoing president makes sweeping moves Trump may try to erase

BY MATT VISER

He’s designated national monuments in California and removed Cuba from the list of state sponsors of terrorism. He’s blocked a Japanese company’s takeover of U.S. Steel and extended temporary protected status to nearly 1 million immigrants. He’s commuted the sentences of nearly everyone who was on federal death row, and he’s granted to his son Hunter a sweeping pardon.

President Joe Biden is ending his time in office as he began, with a burst of executive actions meant to differentiate him from the man who preceded him and will succeed him: President-elect Donald Trump.

Biden’s actions have been far-reaching, touching nearly every area of government, and are likely to continue up until his final hours in office, according to administration officials. Even as many at the White House were packing up their offices — planning to vacate at the end of the day on Friday — there were still last-minute preparations for

SEE **BIDEN** ON **A4**

©**PKCapitol:** In Congress, Biden’s party goes quiet on his legacy. **A7**



In the Los Angeles area, hot, dry weather had turned abundant vegetation tinder-dry.

Winds drove the fire downslope into dense neighborhoods where homes provided fuel.

This is what turned the Southern California fires into a catastrophe.

Satellite views of an Altadena, California, neighborhood blend from Aug. 30 (top) to Jan. 8 (bottom), when the Eaton Fire devastated residential areas full of vulnerable structures.

A NEW KIND OF URBAN FIRESTORM

This article is by John Muyskens, Sarah Kaplan, Niko Kommenda, Naema Ahmed and Simon Ducroquet

Everything around Walker Savage was smoke. Smoke and embers and broken tree limbs and the relentless roar of the wind. Wearing a respirator and goggles from his woodworking studio, he sprayed his garden hose into the gale, hoping to wet the walls and porch of his 99-year-old adobe house enough to keep them from igniting.

But then he saw the flames come surging down the mountain above his home in east Altadena, California: “It was like an avalanche,” Savage said. “But not of snow — it was of fire.”

More than a week later, Savage is still trying to wrap his mind around the Eaton Fire, which killed at least 16 people, destroyed an estimated 7,000 structures and is still only roughly half contained. The flames moved faster than firefighters could fight them, reaching deep into the suburb to scorch houses well outside the state-designated risk zone.

The blazes that have consumed Altadena and the Los Angeles neighborhood of Pacific Palisades hark back to historic urban firestorms — a kind of disaster that was supposed to have been extinguished by the development of modern fire departments and strong building codes.

But decades of development in fire-prone landscapes and rapid planetary warming have

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A community’s loss: Black families in Altadena fear the wildfires will claim their history. **A9**

Israel’s far right balks, delaying vote on ceasefire

NETANYAHU IN TALKS WITH ALLIES

Some say truce too early, but ratification still likely

BY GERRY SHIH AND SHIRA RUBIN

JERUSALEM — The Israeli government delayed Thursday a crucial vote on its proposed ceasefire deal with Hamas as Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu remained locked in difficult negotiations with far-right members of his own coalition who have been pressing for further hostilities.

Even as Israeli officials sought to work out remaining differences with Hamas and clear the way

for an exchange of hostages held in Gaza and prisoners detained in Israel, some of Netanyahu’s own allies decried the agreement as premature, threatening to quit his coalition and bring down the government.

A vote by the Israeli cabinet that had been scheduled for Thursday will now come no sooner than Friday. The Israeli parliament, or Knesset, would then have to endorse the deal before the guns would fall silent and the first hostages would be released.

The developments served as a stark reminder that even though the hard bargaining over a ceasefire has been conducted in Qatar with the help of U.S., Qatari and

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North Gaza: Ceasefire raises hopes of getting more aid into Strip. **A13**



EYAD BABA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Palestinians in central Gaza receive food aid Thursday following the announcement of a ceasefire deal in the 15-month-long war.

Few frills for S. Korean president in detention

Leader who attempted to impose martial law is held in a solitary cell

BY ANDREW JEONG

SEOUL — South Korean President Yoon Suk Yeol woke up Thursday morning in a solitary cell at the Seoul Detention Center. He was served a breakfast of cereal, boiled eggs, nuts and milk — a far cry from the rice, fish and warm broths that professional chefs make at the president’s official residence.

The previous morning, Yoon,

who was impeached last month, became the first South Korean president to be detained while in office. His lawyers failed Thursday evening to have the detainment order invalidated, with a Seoul court ruling that prosecutors were justified in holding the president.

South Korea’s detention centers have had plenty of experience at holding high-profile people, including former presidents and business tycoons. But this is the first time they’ve had to accommodate a sitting president.

So far, it seems Yoon has been given minimal special treatment.

Yoon was detained Wednesday morning on charges of insurrection

SEE **SOUTH KOREA** ON **A14**

DAVID LYNCH 1946-2025

Director put his surreal, dark, dreamlike visions onscreen

BY HARRISON SMITH

David Lynch, the surrealist filmmaker who bridged the mainstream and avant-garde, exploring the sinister recesses of the human psyche — and the mysteries behind America’s white picket fences — with an unsettling blend of melodrama, whimsy and nightmarish horror, has died. He was 78.

His family announced the death in a Facebook post on Thursday but did not share additional details. “There’s a big hole in the world now that he’s no longer with us,” they wrote. “But,



Mr. Lynch

as he would say, ‘Keep your eye on the doughnut and not on the hole.’”

Mr. Lynch revealed in an interview last year that he

had emphysema, adding that the lung disease — which he blamed on years of smoking — had limited his mobility and kept him homebound. He later took to social media amid speculation on his health and the future of his

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IN THE NEWS

Giuliani reaches settlement The former New York mayor avoided trial in a defamation case brought by Georgia election workers. **A6**

Broken elevators, stuck seniors Two lifts in a seven-story D.C. apartment building, out of order for more than a month, have frustrated some of its residents. **B1**

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A rocket launched by Jeff Bezos’s Blue Origin reached orbit in its first test flight. **A3**
The CDC urged health-care workers to test hospitalized flu patients for bird flu. **A10**

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A House Democrat is embracing President-elect Donald Trump’s tariffs pledge and says his party should, too. **A15**
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THE REGION

Two companies that led the messy rollout of the GambetDC platform will pay a \$6.5 million settlement. **B1**

OBITUARIES

Bob Uecker, 90, turned a mediocre career in baseball into one as the game’s preeminent joker. **B4**

STYLE

Gay couples across the country have been racing to marry before the Trump administration begins. **C1**

WEEKEND

The best hand pies in D.C. include pastry-wrapped comfort food from Kenya, Turkey, Cuba and more.

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